

Farming begins

Around 8500 BCE, in southwestern Asia, people began sowing the seeds of cereal plants close to their homes. This spared them long trips to harvest the plants where they grew. At about the same time, these first farmers domesticated (tamed) wild goats, pigs, sheep, and cattle, selecting the best of them as breeding stock to provide meat, milk, and leather.

Domestication

Bigger and better corn

By about 9000 BCE, villagers in Central America had begun to domesticate the teosinte grass. This plant had small cobs with hard outer shells that shattered when harvested. The early farmers selected plants with larger cobs that did not shatter and gradually bred modern corn, or maize.



Wild boar



Modern domestic pig



Teosinte, a wild corn

Modern corn

Tamer pigs

The first pig farmers were hunters in western Asia. In about 7500 BCE, they began keeping selected wild boar in captivity. Over time, they bred the pig, a smaller and more docile animal.



Wild potatoes from Peru

Modern potato

Tastier potatoes

The ancestors of the modern potato were first domesticated in Peru around 8,000 years ago. They were bitter tasting, but cultivation gradually produced improved varieties with better flavors.

2000–1000 BCE
Squash, sunflowers,
knot grass,
small barley

8000–3000 BCE
Peppers, avocados,
corn, squash, beans,
cotton, tomatoes,
turkeys, ducks

NORTH AMERICA

MEXICO

Spread of agriculture

Plants and animals were domesticated independently in several different areas: western Asia, eastern Asia, Central and South America, eastern North America, parts of Africa, and the Indian subcontinent. Farming then spread from these regions across the world.

Tools for the harvest

Farmers developed tools, mainly sickles with curved blades to cut the tough stalks of crops. Early blades were made of polished stone but, as metalworking evolved, they were later made of copper, bronze, and iron.



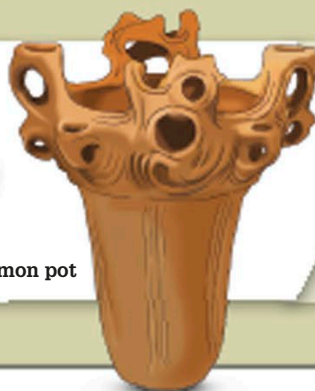
Farm tools with bronze (left) and iron blades

Key events

23,500–22,500 BCE

Hunter-gatherers in the Middle East harvested wild emmer (an early type of wheat), barley, pistachios, and olives. They ground cereals with pestles.

Jomon pot



14,000 BCE

Baked clay pots, essential to future farmers, first appeared in China. But by 14,000 BCE the Jomon people of Japan were the leading producers of high-quality pots.

13,000 BCE

The first domestication of an animal took place when hunters tamed wolves, from which all dogs descend. This probably happened in several areas at the same time.

